Product Bet Canvas

Treat a new product or feature as a bet: who has the problem, what you believe, the riskiest assumptions, and how you'll find out cheaply.

Decide What to Build · Bets, Not Plans · Four Big Risks (Marty Cagan) · Test the Riskiest Assumption First

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

IDEA: Staples subscription
OWNER: Priya
DATE: 14 April

1 The Problem — WHOSE, AND HOW BAD?

Who has it: Families who buy the same staples every week

The problem, in their words: "We always run out of milk and nappies between shops, then pay for a second delivery."

How they cope today: A list on the fridge, a top-up at the corner shop, or a phone reminder.

How often, how painful (1–5): Every week · 4

2 Our Bet — ONE SENTENCE, FOUR PARTS

We believe that (who): families who buy the same staples each week

will (do what): set up a staples subscription and keep it for 3+ months

if we (offer what): deliver their chosen staples automatically with each weekly shop

because (what we know): 38% of baskets repeat 5+ staples; 7 of 10 people we interviewed asked for it

The smallest version we could try: a manual subscription: customers pick 5 staples and we add them by hand to their next order, for 50 customers for 4 weeks (no change to Payments).

3 Why It's Worth It — VALUE AND COST

Value to users: Never run out; one less thing to remember. Fewer second deliveries

Value to us: Predictable orders, easier stock planning. More repeat orders (Q2 objective 1)

Cost of doing nothing: A rival launched subscriptions in March

Roughly what it'll take: Test: 2 people, 4 weeks

4 Riskiest Assumptions — CONFIDENCE 1 (GUESS) – 5 (PROVEN)

RISK	WE'RE ASSUMING…	CONF.
Value Will they want it?	Families keep it for 3+ months	2
Usability Can they use it?	They can pick and change staples easily	3
Feasibility Can we build it?	Payments can do repeat billing	2
Viability Does it work for us?	Margin holds with staples added	3

5 How We'll Test It — CHEAPEST FIRST

TEST	SIGNAL WE NEED	BY WHEN
Fake-door sign-up	over 5% of visitors sign up	2 May
Manual test, 50 customers	70% still subscribed at week 4	6 June
Payments spike	a test repeat charge works	30 June

6 Measures of Success — HOW WE'LL KNOW IT PAID OFF

MEASURE	NOW	TARGET	BY WHEN
Customers with an active subscription	0	5,000	end of Q3
Second order within 2 days	9%	5%	end of Q3
Staples basket margin	21%	21% (hold)	end of Q3

We'll stop or change course if: fewer than half keep it for 4 weeks

7 Decision — GO, TEST, PARK OR NO

- [ ] Go: build the smallest version
- [x] Test first: run the tests above
- [ ] Park it: revisit later
- [ ] No: not worth it, and here's why

Why: Value and feasibility are still guesses (2 out of 5)

Decided by: Priya, with the Basket and Payments leads

Revisit on: 6 June, after the manual test

"What would have to be true for this to be a good bet?"

"What's the cheapest way to find out we're wrong?"

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